

CORE FORMULA

Notice resistance -> name it neutrally -> ask what it carries -> reflect the answer -> adapt or stop. -> Hesitation + neutral label + one diagnostic question + respect for the choice. -> I am hearing some hesitation. What is the main thing that does not work for you? -> I am noticing a yes-but. I do not want to push past it. Is the concern risk, timing, workload, trust, or fit? -> If it reveals a constraint, adapt. If it reveals a value, validate it. If it reveals a firm boundary, stop.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Notice the resistance, name it neutrally, and ask once what it is telling you before you explain, defend, or persuade.

BEST FOR

- Objections to a proposal, request, plan, offer, change, or piece of feedback
- Vague hesitation: "maybe", "I am not sure", "I guess", "yes, but"
- Repeated delays, silence, partial compliance, or guarded agreement
- Workplace disagreement where the real constraint is not yet explicit
- Personal conversations where someone seems reluctant but will not name why
- Coaching or leadership moments where defensiveness may be protecting a real concern
- Repair conversations where the other person has lost trust in the process

PHRASE BANK

Quick openers · Minimum-viable one-liners

- "I am hearing some hesitation. What is the main thing that does not work for you?"
- "Something in this is not landing. What should I understand before I respond?"
- "That resistance is useful information. What is it pointing to?"
- "What is the resistance telling us?"
- "I would rather understand the hesitation than argue past it."
- "What is the actual no or not-yet here?"

Warm / social · Low-pressure, personal

- "I do not want to push past that. What feels off about it?"
- "There is a no in there somewhere. What is the no protecting?"
- "I am not trying to convince you. I want to understand the hesitation first."
- "What part of this feels too much, too soon, or not right?"
- "No pressure. Is something about it not sitting right, or is it just a busy week?"
- "You do not have to explain if you would rather not."
- "Is the issue the idea itself, the timing, or how I am framing it?"

Professional · Work, meetings, proposals

- "I am hearing resistance, which usually means we are missing a constraint. What constraint should we put on the table?"
- "Before I defend the proposal, what is the risk you are seeing?"
- "What information is the pushback giving us about the plan?"
- "Is your concern about priority, workload, trust, evidence, authority, or timing?"
- "What would need to be true for this to become workable?"
- "The action is not moving, which may be useful information. What is making it hard to commit?"
- "Useful signal. Is the concern budget, value, timing, or internal approval?"

Digital / text · Async and written replies

- "I am reading your reply as hesitation rather than a simple no. What is the main blocker?"
- "Useful signal. Is the concern scope, timing, risk, or fit?"
- "Before I respond point-by-point, what is the underlying objection?"
- "I do not want to over-persuade here. What should I understand about the resistance?"
- "Quick check before I reply properly: is this a no, a not-yet, or a yes-if?"

Diagnostic asks · Naming the real blocker

- "Is this a no, a not-yet, or a yes-if?"
- "What part of this feels unworkable?"
- "What condition would need to be met first?"
- "What risk should I be taking more seriously?"
- "What am I missing about how this lands for you?"
- "Is the resistance about the idea, the timing, the trust level, or the amount of pressure?"
- "What is the biggest risk for you if we go ahead?"
- "What would make this workable?"

Boundary-safe · Respecting a no

- "A no is enough; you do not have to justify it. If you want to share the reason, I will listen."
- "We can stop here. I am asking to understand, not to reopen pressure."
- "If this is a firm boundary, I will respect it and not keep probing."
- "You do not have to justify it. I asked to understand, not to push."
- "Is it useful to unpack the hesitation, or would you rather leave it there?"
- "I can work with that. We can adapt, pause, or drop it."

Under pressure · Conflict and debate

- "Let us pause the persuasion for a moment. What is the resistance telling us?"
- "I do not want to bulldoze the concern. Name the blocker and I will work with that."
- "Before this turns into a debate, what is the actual no or not-yet?"
- "What risk are you trying to prevent by pushing back?"
- "I do not want to sell past this. What is the resistance telling us about the plan?"
- "If this is a firm no, I will respect it. If it is a not-yet, what would need to change?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "Why are you being so negative?"

Better: "I hear the concern. What is the biggest risk for you?"

Best: "I am hearing some hesitation, and I do not want to push past it. What is the resistance telling us about the plan?"

2. Weak: "You just do not understand the benefits."

Better: "Is the issue timing, workload, or something else?"

Best: "If this is a firm no, I will respect it. If it is a not-yet, what condition would need to change?"

3. Weak: "It is only a few emails, it should not be that hard."

Better: "What is the main blocker on the timing?"

Best: "So the issue is quality risk, not unwillingness — what deadline would protect accuracy?"

DECISION TREE

If The resistance is a firm boundary or a safety signal

Respect it. Do not probe unless the person invites discussion.

"Understood. I will leave it there."

If You have not yet asked what the resistance means

Name it neutrally and ask one diagnostic question.

"I am hearing some hesitation. What is the main thing that does not work?"

If The answer revealed a real constraint, risk, value, or missing condition

Reflect it back and adapt the plan.

"So the issue is quality risk, not unwillingness. What deadline would protect accuracy?"

If You asked but nothing concrete surfaced

Ask one narrower diagnostic question.

"Is the concern the idea, the timing, the trust level, or the pressure?"

If The person is becoming more tense or less clear

Release pressure and offer to stop.

"You do not have to justify it. We can leave this here."

If The blocker is now clear — choose the next move

Chain into the right package: validation for a concern, autonomy release for choice pressure, SBI for feedback pushback, NVC for an unmet need, a clean request for practical adaptation.

"That makes sense. What would make this workable?"

SCENARIOS

Team member resists a deadline

Pause defending the deadline; name the timing resistance and find the real blocker — workload, approvals, quality risk, or unclear scope. — "I am hearing timing resistance. What is the blocker?"

A friend seems reluctant to attend

Keep it low-pressure; offer an easy exit and a lighter option rather than pressing for a reason. — "No pressure. Is something about it not sitting right, or is it just a busy week?"

A client objects to price

Treat it as a fit signal, not a hurdle; find which concern it is before you respond, and do not use the answer to corner them. — "Useful signal. Is the concern budget, value, timing, or internal approval?"

A partner resists feedback

Check how the feedback is landing before repeating it; repair the tone if it is landing as blame. — "I think this may be landing as blame. What are you hearing me say?"

A stakeholder resists a change initiative

Read polite-but-no-action as data; look for authority, trust, incentives, or workload behind the stall. — "The action is not moving, which may be useful. What is making it hard to commit?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They have given a clear boundary and do not want to explain it
- There is danger, abuse, coercion, or a need for immediate safety action
- You are using the question to keep a negotiation open after a no
- You cannot accept that the information may point to stopping
- The person is overwhelmed and needs space rather than inquiry
- You are not actually willing to adapt based on what you learn

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot resistance

Through the day, notice three moments of resistance — a no, a delay, a "yes, but", a topic change, or tense agreement. Write down the exact surface words each time.

Day 2 — Name the form

For each moment, label the form: objection, silence, delay, humour, defensiveness, vague agreement, or firm no. Notice which form you meet most often.

Day 3 — List the hidden information

Take one of those moments and list five things the resistance might be carrying: a constraint, a risk, a value, a trust signal, or a boundary.

Day 4 — Draft neutral labels

Practise naming resistance without drama. Write three low-key labels you could say out loud: "I am hearing hesitation", "Something is not landing", "There is a blocker here".

Day 5 — Draft the diagnostic question

Write one clean diagnostic question for each label — for example "What is the main thing that does not work?" or "Is this a no, a not-yet, or a yes-if?" Say each aloud once.

Day 6 — Add the recovery line

Write one recovery phrase that restores choice if the question starts to feel like pressure: "You do not have to justify it — I asked to understand, not to push." Rehearse it until it sounds natural.

Day 7 — Use it live

In one real conversation, run the whole move once: notice, name neutrally, ask one question, listen, then adapt or stop. Afterwards, note what the resistance actually revealed.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- What form did the resistance take — objection, silence, delay, humour, defensiveness, vague agreement, or firm no?
- Did I treat the resistance as information, or as an obstacle to remove?
- Did I ask one clean diagnostic question, or did I interrogate?
- What did it reveal — a constraint, risk, value, boundary, missing trust, or missing condition?
- Did my next move actually change based on what I learned?
- Did I restore autonomy if the person seemed pressured?